



The Year Of The Laptop

Until 2004, the notebook was a luxury. This year, get ready for the laptop boom!

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Take these figures released recently by research firm IDC: Globally, laptops have now reached 24 per cent of overall PC sales, up from 20 per cent last year, and 18 per cent the year before that. IDC is bullish about laptop sales in India too. According to its figures, the laptop market grew 65 per cent in 2003 in revenue terms. IDC's report adds that with these figures, it will not be long before laptops will form a quarter of all PC sales.

WHAT TO EXPECT IN 2005 Lightweight Notebooks

It is the year to be practical as well as extravagant. Laptops are normally used by executives who travel regularly. Therefore, industry experts say that the emphasis would be on reducing the weight of the laptop, making it easy to carry around. The heavier laptops, on the other hand, would be addressed to the less weight-conscious home-user segment. The heavier laptops, which are normally priced much lower than their lightweight counterparts and have similar util-

ity, make up for around 80 per cent of the consumer laptop market.

Wide Screens

This year will also see an increased emphasis on wide screens; the prime reason being laptops are no longer used just for business purposes but also as entertainment units. Although screen sizes and resolutions have improved dramatically in the last six to eight months, prices have not dropped in the same proportion as PCs. Says Devita Saraf, executive director (marketing), Zenith Computers: "Laptop prices have dropped, but not dramatically. This is primarily because prices of LCD displays have remained either high or stable."

Battery Life

A regular pique of laptop users is battery life. Charging is a pain; indeed in most cases impossible. Imagine your battery giving up in the middle of an important presentation. This year, however, would see a dramatic rise in battery life. "Newly-launched models should have at least seven to eight hours of battery life," says Rajiev Grover, country category manager, consumer portables, Hewlett Packard India.

Price

Several factors may contribute to the upswing in the demand for notebooks in 2005, but the biggest factor would still be price. Component prices are expected to drop this year. Grover

